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Rip those dead white people off
your walls Black People
black people whose walls
should be a hall
A Black Hall Of Fame 85
so our children will know
will know & be proud
Proud to say I'm from Parker City—Coltrane City—Ornette City
Pharoah City living on Holiday street next to
James Brown[8] park in the State of Malcolm 90

How Long
how long
will it take for you to understand
that Tranes been gone
riding in a portable radio 95
next to your son who's lonely
Who walks walks walks into nothing
no city no state no home no Nothing
how long
How long 100
Have black people been gone

1969

8. Popular soul singer (b. 1928). Ferrell "Pharoah" Sanders (b. 1940), tenor saxophonist who played in Coltrane's quartet from 1965 to 1967. Billie Holiday (1915–1959), jazz singer.

LARRY NEAL
1937–1981

Poet, essayist, theorist, editor, playwright, literary and music critic, pianist and flutist, filmmaker, screenwriter, folklorist, scholar, teacher, Larry Neal was the intellectual leader of the Black Arts movement. One of the most subtle theorists of the era's articulation of aesthetics and politics and a leading practitioner of its many expressive forms, Neal is remembered especially for a series of incisive essays produced in the decade from the mid-1960s to the mid-1970s that not only gave the Black Arts movement its name and aspects of its distinctive style, but also provided, in sinewy prose, cogent declarations of its philosophical foundations, cultural conditions, and revolutionary aspirations.

The oldest of five sons, Lawrence Paul Neal was born on September 5, 1937, in Atlanta, Georgia, to Woodie and Maggie Neal. Both parents were strong influences on Neal and nurtured him with a rich sense of cultural inheritance. In a "personal note" attached to his second volume of poetry, *Hoodoo Hollerin' Bebop Ghosts* (1971), Neal writes of his father as the first nationalist he ever knew, a man who had less than a high school education but was exceptionally well-read, insistent on self-reliance and practicality, and "in the most memorable sense of the term, say in the tradition of Walter White, Marcus Garvey, and A. J. Rodgers, a 'race man.'" If his father gave him a political and legal education (Woodie Neal,

after serving in WWII as a battleship pipe fitter and a switchman for the Reading Railroad, was also "a fugitive from the Georgia law of the thirties," Neal claimed), his mother "represents the aesthetic side of the family." A lover of music and poetry, Neal's mother would recite poetry by Paul Laurence Dunbar and Langston Hughes to her children and was committed to Neal's receiving an education in music and the arts.

The family moved to North Philadelphia when Neal was quite young, settling in the Johnson Housing Projects; it was there that his mother, determined to have her sons well educated, converted to Catholicism (at Saint Elizabeth's Church) so that they could enroll in a Catholic school. Neal graduated from Roman Catholic High School in Philadelphia in 1956 and then took a degree in English and history from Lincoln University in 1961. In 1963 Neal earned an M.A. from the University of Pennsylvania in folklore (a perpetual interest in Neal's poetry, prose, and drama) before moving to New York in 1964 and a year later marrying Evelyn Rodgers (a chemist originally from Fairfield, Alabama).

Larry and Evelyn settled into Harlem in a section then called Sugar Hill, where their brownstone became a hub of cultural energy until his untimely death of a heart attack in January of 1981. Harlem proved to be invigorating for Neal, a place full of important literary figures such as Ishmael Reed, Quincy Troupe, Askia Muhammad Touré, Stanley Crouch, Henry Dumas, and Amiri Baraka. Though his first job in Harlem was as a copy editor for John Wiley and Sons, he almost immediately became involved (whether as founder, editor, and/or contributor) in many of the progressive black "little magazines" of the 1960s—*Liberator*, *Soulbook*, the *Journal of Black Poetry*, *Black Theater*, and *Black World*—for which he variously wrote journalistic accounts of cultural events, conducted interviews with writers, artists, and musicians, and published his own creative and critical work. This period also marked Neal's increased involvement in the Black Liberation movement, which gradually shaped his writing and brought him closer especially with Baraka, with whom he shared a growing skepticism, inspired by Malcolm X, of Martin Luther King's nonviolent approach to black liberation.

Uncompromising yet deeply learned in his avowals of radical black politics, Neal found himself at the heart of black nationalist struggle. In a nearly emblematic event, Neal was wounded while leaving the Schomburg Center for Research in Black Culture in 1965 by someone who ostensibly loathed his politics. But such violence did not slow him down. In the mid-1960s he co-directed, with Baraka and Touré, the critically important and controversial Black Arts Repertory Theatre/School in Harlem, which produced works such as Baraka's *Jello* and *Dutchman* and provided a space for poetry readings and concerts focused on themes of revolutionary community. As Neal's involvement with theater increased, so did his subtlety in thinking about music and performance, both of which became increasingly central to his aesthetic theories and political practices. Neal continued to write important criticism on figures such as Ralph Ellison, Albert Murray, Baraka, and Archie Shepp while working out his own ideas and formulating new projects.

Published the same year as the movement's most important manifesto (the 1968 anthology of poetry and prose called *Black Fire*, which Neal edited with Baraka), Neal's eponymous essay "The Black Arts Movement" sounds one of the period's most definitive moments of expressive self-assertion. Indeed, declaring black art to be "the aesthetic and spiritual sister of the Black Power concept," "The Black Arts Movement" essay, like Neal's poetry, plays, and other prose, fundamentally addresses itself to "the Afro-American desire for self-determination and nationhood," opposing itself "to any concept of the artist that alienates him from his community." The nationalist turn from civil rights to black liberation was, in Neal's view, also a movement away from parochialism; black nationhood could not be truly imagined, let alone accomplished, without a revaluation of Western notions of aesthetics, agency, subjectivity, and tradition. Thus, for Neal the politics of the Black Power movement are inextricably tied to "a radical reordering of the nature and function of both art and the artist" and a "dissolution" of the Western focus on individual identity.

The late 1960s and early 1970s were a remarkably productive period for Neal, as he attempted to maintain a continuity with the Black Arts movement while refining his revisionary critical flair in ever subtler thinking about the relationships between aesthetics and politics, identity and community, and art and philosophy. In addition to numerous screenplays, scripts for television, and documentaries, Neal wrote and produced two major plays during his lifetime, *The Glorious Monster in the Bell of the Horn* (1976) and *In an Upstate Motel* (1981). One critic described *The Glorious Monster* as a "lyric drama, a poetic interpretation of the hopes and aspirations of black artists and the middle class on the eve of the dropping of the A-bomb on Hiroshima." Staged by the Negro Ensemble Company in the spring of 1981, *In an Upstate Motel* was existentially darker than *Glorious Monster*, offering a tense drama about the aftermath of a failed assassination attempt made by a black man and woman (cocaine addicts and sexual partners); in a contemporary *New York Times* review, Frank Rich wrote of Neal as having taken "a familiar premise—a gangland hit man and his woman on the lam—and infused it with Proustian ghosts, Pinteresque menace, even a dash of jazz."

At this time, Neal grew increasingly involved with the world of academia and formal cultural institutions, teaching at numerous universities and working as a consultant for a number of arts foundations. Neal held the Andrew W. Mellon chair in humanities at Howard University and received a Guggenheim Fellowship in 1971. He also served as executive director of the DC Commission on the Arts and Humanities from 1976 to 1979.

During this period, Neal continued to publish a prolific stream of poetry, prose, drama, TV, and film. The poems anthologized here offer just a sampling of the richly diverse traditions on which Neal drew. It is nearly impossible to separate the media in which Neal worked: music, performance, and poetry especially shared elements that Neal sought to bring together in what he calls (in the afterword to *Black Fire*) "new syntheses." Like many of the other writers of the Black Arts era, Neal focused on music as the quintessential art ("Our music has always been the most dominant manifestation of what we are and feel, literature was just an afterthought"); but he also incorporated music and performance into his poetics, seeking a language that didn't imitate music but that enacted its philosophical and formal imperatives. Indeed, Neal wrote, "the poet must become a performer, the way James Brown is a performer—loud, gaudy, and racy. He must take his work where his people are: Harlem, Watts, Philadelphia, Chicago, and the rural South. . . . Poets must learn to sing, dance, and chant their work, tearing into the substance of their individual and collective experiences. We must make literature move people to a deeper understanding of what this thing is all about, be a kind of priest, a black magician, working juju with the word on the world."

The poems included here—all from *Hoodoo Hollerin' Bebop Ghosts*—evince this artistic urgency and the formal inventiveness that gives that urgency structural clarity and thematic character. In an interview, Neal once described this volume as "a book full of ghosts' voices," a poetic attempt to "understand and manipulate the collective myths of the race" that themselves exert spectral energies of history, loss, and labor on the poet's task. This ghostly purpose roots Neal's voice in traditional idioms of hoodoo, slavery, and African and African American myth, while remaining startlingly fresh, not least on account of the rich re-imagining of inherited figures and images of a culture undergoing constant displacement and renewal. Continuity and revision, ritual and performance, music and style, spectrality and power—these, and many others, are the topics that constitute Neal's unique poetics, a poetics—whether somberly "bearing witness" or jubilantly "riffing"—that are as much concerned with transgressive critique ("So we pick up our axes and prepare / to blast the white dream"; "Don't Say Goodbye to the Porkpie Hat") as it is with confronting violation, death, love—the very elements of black experience that do not just contain but inspire Neal's hope for communal liberation.

The Black Arts Movement

I

The Black Arts Movement is radically opposed to any concept of the artist that alienates him from his community. Black Art is the aesthetic and spiritual sister of the Black Power concept. As such, it envisions an art that speaks directly to the needs and aspirations of Black America. In order to perform this task, the Black Arts Movement proposes a radical reordering of the western cultural aesthetic. It proposes a separate symbolism, mythology, critique, and iconology. The Black Arts and the Black Power concept both relate broadly to the Afro-American's desire for self-determination and nationhood. Both concepts are nationalistic. One is concerned with the relationship between art and politics; the other with the art of politics.

Recently, these two movements have begun to merge: the political values inherent in the Black Power concept are now finding concrete expression in the aesthetics of Afro-American dramatists, poets, choreographers, musicians, and novelists. A main tenet of Black Power is the necessity for Black people to define the world in their own terms. The Black artist has made the same point in the context of aesthetics. The two movements postulate that there are in fact and in spirit two Americas—one black, one white. The Black artist takes this to mean that his primary duty is to speak to the spiritual and cultural needs of Black people. Therefore, the main thrust of this new breed of contemporary writers is to confront the contradictions arising out of the Black man's experience in the racist West. Currently, these writers are re-evaluating western aesthetics, the traditional role of the writer, and the social function of art. Implicit in this re-evaluation is the need to develop a "black aesthetic." It is the opinion of many Black writers, I among them, that the Western aesthetic has run its course: it is impossible to construct anything meaningful within its decaying structure. We advocate a cultural revolution in art and ideas. The cultural values inherent in western history must either be radicalized or destroyed, and we will probably find that even radicalization is impossible. In fact, what is needed is a whole new system of ideas. Poet Don L. Lee[1] expresses it:

> . . . We must destroy Faulkner, dick, jane, and other perpetuators of evil. It's time for DuBois, Nat Turner, and Kwame Nkrumah. As Frantz Fanon[2] points out: destroy the culture and you destroy the people. This must not happen. Black artists are culture stabilizers; bringing back old values, and introducing new ones. Black Art will talk to the people and with the will of the people stop impending "protective custody."

The Black Arts Movement eschews "protest" literature. It speaks directly to Black people. Implicit in the concept of "protest" literature, as Brother Knight[3] has made clear, is an appeal to white morality:

1. African American poet and critic Lee (b. 1942) is now known as Haki Madhubuti; the remarks Neal cites below are from a symposium on the question "Should black writers direct their work toward black audiences?" published in *Negro Digest* in January 1968.
2. Martinican psychiatrist (1925–1961), author of several important critiques of racism and colonialism. William Faulkner (1897–1962), modernist writer from Mississippi. W. E. B. Du Bois (1865–1963), scholar, editor of *Crisis* (1909–34), and co-founder of the NAACP. Turner (1800–1831), leader of an 1831 slave rebellion in Virginia. Nkrumah (1909–1972), first president of independent Ghana.
3. Etheridge Knight (1931–1985), poet. The remarks Neal cites are from the January 1968 *Negro Digest* symposium.

> Now any Black man who masters the technique of his particular art form, who adheres to the white aesthetic, and who directs his work toward a white audience is, in one sense, protesting. And implicit in the act of protest is the belief that a change will be forthcoming once the masters are aware of the protestor's "grievance" (the very word connotes begging, supplications to the gods). Only when that belief has faded and protestings end, will Black art begin.

Brother Knight also has some interesting statements about the development of a "Black aesthetic":

> Unless the Black artist establishes a "Black aesthetic" he will have no future at all. To accept the white aesthetic is to accept and validate a society that will not allow him to live. The Black artist must create new forms and new values, sing new songs (or purify old ones); and along with other Black authorities, he must create a new history, new symbols, myths and legends (and purify old ones by fire). And the Black artist, in creating his own aesthetic, must be accountable for it only to the Black people. Further, he must hasten his own dissolution as an individual (in the Western sense)—painful though the process may be, having been breast-fed the poison of "individual experience."

When we speak of a "Black aesthetic" several things are meant. First, we assume that there is already in existence the basis for such an aesthetic. Essentially, it consists of an African-American cultural tradition. But this aesthetic is finally, by implication, broader than that tradition. It encompasses most of the useable elements of Third World culture. The motive behind the Black aesthetic is the destruction of the white thing, the destruction of white ideas, and white ways of looking at the world. The new aesthetic is mostly predicated on an Ethics which asks the question: whose vision of the world is finally more meaningful, ours or the white oppressors'? What is truth? Or more precisely, whose truth shall we express, that of the oppressed or of the oppressors? These are basic questions. Black intellectuals of previous decades failed to ask them. Further, national and international affairs demand that we appraise the world in terms of our own interests. It is clear that the question of human survival is at the core of contemporary experience. The Black artist must address himself to this reality in the strongest terms possible. In a context of world upheaval, ethics and aesthetics must interact positively and be consistent with the demands for a more spiritual world. Consequently, the Black Arts Movement is an ethical movement. Ethical, that is, from the viewpoint of the oppressed. And much of the oppression confronting the Third World and Black America is directly traceable to the Euro-American cultural sensibility. This sensibility, anti-human in nature, has, until recently, dominated the psyches of most Black artists and intellectuals; it must be destroyed before the Black creative artist can have a meaningful role in the transformation of society.

It is this natural reaction to an alien sensibility that informs the cultural attitudes of the Black Arts and the Black Power movement. It is a profound ethical sense that makes a Black artist question a society in which art is one thing and the actions of men another. The Black Arts Movement believes

that your ethics and your aesthetics are one.[4] That the contradiction between ethics and aesthetics in western society is symptomatic of a dying culture.

The term "Black Arts" is of ancient origin, but it was first used in a positive sense by LeRoi Jones:

> We are unfair
> And unfair
> We are black magicians
> Black arts we make
> in black labs of the heart
>
> The fair are fair
> and deathly white
>
> The day will not save them
> And we own the night[5]

There is also a section of the poem "Black Dada Nihilismus" that carries the same motif. But a fuller amplification of the nature of the new aesthetics appears in the poem "Black Art":

> Poems are bullshit unless they are
> teeth or trees or lemons piled
> on a step. Or black ladies dying
> of men leaving nickel hearts
> beating them down. Fuck poems
> and they are useful, wd they shoot
> come at you, love what you are,
> breathe like wrestlers, or shudder
> strangely after pissing. We want live
> words of the hip world, live flesh &
> coursing blood. Hearts Brains
> Souls splintering fire. We want poems
> like fists beating niggers out of Jocks
> or dagger poems in the slimy bellies
> of the owner-jews . . .

Poetry is a concrete function, an action. No more abstractions. Poems are physical entities: fists, daggers, airplane poems, and poems that shoot guns. Poems are transformed from physical objects into personal forces:

> . . . Put it on him poem. Strip him naked
> to the world! Another bad poem cracking
> steel knuckles in a jewlady's mouth
> Poem scream poison gas on breasts in green berets . . .

Then the poem affirms the integral relationship between Black Art and Black people:

> . . . Let Black people understand
> that they are the lovers and the sons
> of lovers and warriors and sons

4. Reference to Austrian-British philosopher Ludwig Wittgenstein's *Tractatus Logico-Philosophicus* (1921), Proposition 6.

5. From Amiri Baraka's poem "In Memory of Malcolm" (1965).

of warriors Are poems & poets &
all the loveliness here in the world

It ends with the following lines, a central assertion in both the Black Arts Movement and the philosophy of Black Power:

We want a black poem. And a
Black World.
Let the world be a Black Poem
And let All Black People Speak This Poem
Silently
or LOUD

The poem comes to stand for the collective conscious and unconscious of Black America—the real impulse in back of the Black Power movement, which is the will toward self-determination and nationhood, a radical reordering of the nature and function of both art and the artist.

1968

Some Reflections on the Black Aesthetic

This outline below is a rough overview of some categories and elements that constituted a "Black Aesthetic"[1] outlook. All of these categories need further elaboration, so I am working on a larger essay that will tie them all together.

Mythology Spirit worship, Orishas, ancestors, African Gods. Syncretism/catholic voodoo, macumba,[2] Holy Ghost, Jesus as somebody you might know, like a personal deity. River spirits.	*formal manifestation* Samba, Calypso, Batucada, Cha-Cha, juba, gospel songs, jubilees, work song, spirituals.[3]	1. RACE MEMORY[4] (Africa, Middle Passage) Rhythm as an expression of race memory; rhythm as a basic creative principle; rhythm as existence, creative force as vector of existence. Swinging[5] 2. MIDDLE PASSAGE[6] (Diaspora) Race memory: terror, landlessness, claustrophobia: "America is a prison . . ." Malcolm X.[7]

1. Black Arts movement theorist Hoyt Fuller coined the term "black aesthetic" to denote what he called "a system of isolating and evaluating the artistic works of black people which reflects the special characteristics and imperatives of black experience" ("Towards a Black Aesthetic," 1968). In the wake of Fuller's manifesto, efforts to elaborate "a Black Aesthetic" were undertaken by such writers as Amiri Baraka, Addison Gayle, Stephen Henderson, Maulana Ron Karenga, and Neal.
2. Bantu religious practices in Afro-Brazilian communities; "Orishas": spirits of deities in the religious system of the Yoruba, a West African ethnic group; "Syncretism": the melding of beliefs and practices from different religious traditions; "voodoo": a syncretic religion that melds Dahomean voudon with Catholicism, practiced chiefly in Haiti.
3. "Gospel songs, jubilees, work song, spirituals": musical genres deriving from African American slave experience; "Samba, Calypso, Batucanda, Cha-Cha, juba": dances and musical traditions of Afro-Latino derivation.
4. In psychology, posited memories, feelings, and ideas inherited from one's ancestors.
5. Stylish, sophisticated, lively.
6. The forced voyage of African slaves to the Americas, leading to the scattering ("diaspora") of African peoples through the New World.
7. African American activist and black nationalist leader (1925–1965); Malcolm uttered the phrase "America is a prison" in many speeches, most famously in "Message to the Grass Roots" (1963).

Neo-Mythology Shamans: Preachers, poets, blues singers, musicians, mackdaddies,[8] and politicians.	*formal manifestation* All aspects of Black dance styles in the New World. Pelvic. Dress and walk.	3. TRANSMUTATION AND SYNTHESIS Funky Butt, Stomps, Jump Jim Crow, Buck 'n' Wing, Jigs, Snake, Grind, slow drag, jitterbug, twist, Watusi, fish, swim, boogaloo, etc.[9] Dance to the *after* beat.[1] Dance as race memory; transmitted through the collective folk consciousness.
Neo-Mythology Legba, Oshun, Yemaya, Urzulie,[2] Soul Momma, Evil women, Good loving women, woman as primarily need/ man as doer. Blues singer as poet and moral judge; bad man Earth centered, but directed cosmologically. Folk poet, philosopher, priest, priestess, conjurer,[3] preacher, teacher, hustler, seer, soothsayer[4] . . .		4. BLUES GOD/TONE AS MEANING AND MEMORY Sound as racial memory, primeval. Life breath. Word is perceived as energy or force. Call and response Blues perceived as an emanation outside of man, but yet a manifestation of his being/reality. Same energy source as Gospel, field holler,[5] but delineated in narrative song. The African voice transplanted. This God must be the meanest and the strongest. He survives and persists Once perceived as an evil force: ". . . and I (Dude Botley)[6] got to thinking about how many thousands of people (Buddy) Bolden had made happy and all of them women who used to idolize him 'Where are they now?' I say to myself,

8. Conspicuously successful pimps (slang); "shamans": priests or priestesses who use magic to heal the sick or gain access to the spirit world.
9. "Funky Butt . . . boogaloo": African American dances of the 1940s, 1950s, and 1960s.
1. Reference to the syncopated rhythm characteristic of blues and jazz.
2. Or Oxun: orisha of sexual passion and fertility, a river deity; Legba: orisha of crossroads, doorways, and gates, a messenger and trickster deity; Oshun: orisha of love, beauty, wealth, and diplomacy; Yemaya: orisha of the moon, sea-mother.
3. In the African American syncretic religion known as hoodoo, a person considered to have power over the spirit world.
4. Fortune-teller or oracle.
5. Form of vocal music originating in slavery, akin to the work song.
6. Apocryphal New Orleans musician, often cited as an eyewitness expert on the African American cornetist Charles Joseph "Buddy" Bolden (1877–1931), originator of a New Orleans style of early jazz known as ragtime. Neal quotes extensively here a passage from *Jazz Masters of New Orleans* (1967), by jazz historian Martin T. Williams (1924–1992).

Then I hear Bolden's cornet. I look through the crack and there he is, relaxed back in the chair, blowing that silver cornet softly, just above a whisper, and I see he's got his hat over the bell of the horn. I put my ear close to the keyhole. I thought I heard Bolden play the blues before, and play hymns at funerals, but what he is playing now is real strange and I listen carefully, because he's playing something that for a while sounds like the blues, then like a hymn. I cannot make out the tune, but after awhile I catch on. He is mixing up the blues with the hymns. He plays the blues real sad and the hymn sadder than the blues and then the blues sadder than the hymn. That is the first time that I had ever heard hymns and blues cooked up together. A strange cold feeling comes over me; I get sort of scared because I know the Lord don't like that mixing the Devil's music with his music. . . . It sounded like a battle between the Good Lord and the Devil. Something tells me to listen and see who wins. If Bolden stops on the hymn, the Good Lord wins; if he stops on the blues, the Devil wins."

5. BLACK ARTS MOVEMENT/BLACK ART AESTHETIC
Feeling/ contemporary and historical. Energy intensifies.

HISTORY AS UNITARY MYTH
Shango, Nat Turner, Denmark, Vesey, Brer' Rabbit, High John

HISTORY AS UNITARY MYTH (cont'd)
the Conqueror, Jack Johnson, Ray Robinson, Signifying Monkey, Malcolm X, Adam Clayton Powell, Garvey, DuBois, Hon. Elijah Muhammed, Martin L. King, Rap Brown, Rev. Franklin, Charlie Parker, Duke Ellington,[7] James Brown, Bessie Smith, Moms Mabley, King Pleasure, Raefilt Johnson. Son House. Louis Armstrong. . . . [1]
Voodoo again/Ishmael Reed's Hoodoo. Islamic suffis.[2]
Third World's destiny. The East as the Womb and the Tomb. Fanon's[3] Third World, Bandung Humanism.[4]

5. BLACK ARTS MOVEMENT/BLACK ART AESTHETIC (cont'd)
Non-matrixed art forms: Coltrane, Ornette, Sun Ra.[8] More concerned with the vibrations of the Word, than with the Word itself. Like signifying.[9] The Black Nation as Poem. Ethical stance as aesthetic. The synthesis of the above presented outline. The integral unity of culture, politics, and art. Spiritual. Despises alienation in the European sense. Art consciously committed; art addressed primarily to Black and Third World people. Black attempts to realize the world as art by making Man more

7. Edward Kennedy "Duke" Ellington (1899–1974), jazz pianist, composer, and band leader; Shango: orisha of fire, lightning, and thunder; Nat Turner (1800–1831) and Denmark Vesey (1767–1822), leaders of slave rebellions; Brer' Rabbit, High John the Conqueror, and Signifying Monkey: heroes of African American folk culture who defy authority through wit, magic, and deception, respectively; John Arthur "Jack" (1878–1946) and Sugar Ray Robinson (born Walter Smith Jr., 1921–1989): African American boxing champions; Malcolm X (born Malcolm Little, 1925–1965), black nationalist, minister of the Nation of Islam, and human rights activist; Adam Clayton Powell Sr. (1865–1953): pastor of Abyssinian Baptist Church, a large activist congregation in Harlem, whose son Adam Clayton Powell Jr. (1908–1972) was the first African American elected to Congress from New York City; Marcus Mosiah Garvey Jr. (1887–1940), Jamaican-born political leader, founder of the Universal Negro Improvement Association and advocate of the "Back to Africa" movement; W. E. B. Du Bois (1868–1963), African American sociologist, author, civil rights activist, and Pan-African political philosopher; Elijah Muhammad (born Elijah Robert Poole, 1897–1975), leader of the Nation of Islam from 1934 to 1975); Martin Luther King Jr. (1929–1968), African American civil rights leader and co-founder of the Southern Christian Leadership Conference; H. Rap Brown, later known as Jamil Abdullah Al-Amin (b. 1943), chairman of the Student Nonviolent Coordinating Committee (SNCC) and minister of justice for the Black Panther Party in the 1960s; Reverend C. L. Franklin (1915–1984), African American preacher and civil rights activist, father of the legendary soul and gospel singer Aretha Franklin (b. 1942); Charles "Charlie" Parker Jr. (1920–1955), African American jazz saxophonist and composer known for advancing the "bebop" style of jazz.
8. Sun Ra (born Herman Poole Blount, 1914–1993); Ornette Coleman (b. 1930); John Coltrane (1926–1967): avant-garde jazz saxophonists and composers whose "non-matrixed" styles departed from conventional musical time signatures or measures.
9. Or signifyin': African American verbal strategy of indirection that exploits the gap between literal and metaphorical meaning.
1. African American jazz trumpeter, singer, and composer (1901–1971); James Brown (1933–2006): African American singer and songwriter known as the "King of Soul," an originator of funk music; Bessie Smith (1894–1927): African American blues singer; Jackie "Moms" Mabley (born Loretta Mary Aiken, 1894–1975): African American comedian and pioneer of the so-called Chitlin' Circuit of African American vaudeville; King Pleasure (born Clarence Beeks, 1922–1981), African American jazz vocalist; Eddie James "Son" House (1902–1988): African American blues singer-songwriter.
2. Followers of an Islamic form of mysticism. "Voodoo again/Ishmael Reed's hoodoo": African American writer Ishmael Reed (b. 1938), creator of a style of writing that blends aspects of the Haitian syncretic religion Voodoo, or Vodou, and hoodoo, an African American syncretic religious practice also known as "conjure."
3. Franz Fanon (1925–1961), Martinique-born French-Algerian philosopher, psychiatrist, and post-colonial writer.
4. Pan-African philosophical and political theory promoted by the Revolutionary Action Movement (RAM), led by Robert F. Williams (1925–1996). RAM's 1964 conference "The Black Revolution's Relationship to the Bandung World" evoked the first Asian-African Conference of newly independent African and Asian states that took place in the Indonesian city of Bandung in 1955.

Revolution is the operational mythology. Symbol change. Expanded metaphors as in the poetry of Curtis Lyle and Stanley Crouch; or L. Barrett's *Song For MuMu*[5] . . . Nigger styles and masks such as Rinehart in the *Invisible Man.*[6] Style as in James P. Johnson description of stride pianists in the twenties. Bobby Blue Bland wearing a dashiki[7] and a process. All of this links up with the transmutation of African styles and the revitalization of these styles in the West. compatible to it and it more compatible to Man. Styles itself from nigger rhythms to cosmic sensibility. Black love, conscious and affirmed. Change.

1972

Uncle Rufus Raps on the Squared Circle[1]

> Once I saw a prize fighter boxing a yokel. The fighter was swift and amazingly scientific. His body was one violent flow of rapid rhythmic action. He hit the yokel a hundred times while the yokel held up his arms in stunned surprise. But suddenly the yokel, rolling about in the gale of boxing gloves, struck one blow and knocked science, speed and footwork as cold as a well-digger's posterior. The smart money hit the canvas. The long shot got the nod. The yokel had simply stepped inside of his opponent's sense of time.
>
> —Ralph Ellison, *Invisible Man*

Sporting events, like beauty contests, horse shows, public assassinations—all forms of spectacle—have implicit within them a distinct metaphysical character, said Uncle Rufus while lighting his cigar. We had been talking about the Ali-Frazier fight.[2] He had once been a boxer. Then later he became a singer and dancer in a minstrel show.[3] Needless to say, Uncle Rufus is a most fascinating gentleman. Following our discussion, I discovered that he was

5. Carlto Lindsay Barrett (b. 1941), Jamaican writer and photographer, who published his first novel, *Song for MuMu*, in 1967; K. Curtis Lyle, African American poet and founder of the Watts Writers Workshop in Los Angeles; Stanley Crouch (b. 1945), African American poet, novelist, and critic.
6. Rinehart, an elusive character in the 1952 novel *Invisible Man* by Ralph Ellison (1914–1994), appears only by reputation of his multiple guises, including pimp, bookie, and preacher.
7. Loose-fitting pullover garment, usually colorful, common in West Africa and popular among African American men in the 1960s and 1970s; Robert Calvin "Bobby Blue" Bland (b. 1930), African American blues and soul singer.
1. "Squaring the circle," a mathematical conundrum originating among Babylonian geometers, is a metaphor for an impossible task such as proving rational truth for a transcendental rather than material reality. "Raps": expounds on orally, often in a long monologue (African American vernacular).
2. Also known as the "Fight of the Century," the fight between heavyweight champion Joe Frazier (1944–2011) and Muhammad Ali (born Cassius Marcellus Clay Jr., 1942) occurred on March 8, 1971, in New York City. After refusing to enter the U.S. Army in 1967 on grounds of religious conscientious objection, Ali had become a symbol of anti-establishment rebellion, while Frazier was taken as representative of a more conservative stance within the African American community; the fight was thus widely taken as symbolic of national tensions in the early 1970s.
3. American form of spectacle consisting of comic and musical acts performed by actors in blackface.